



Outlook

Zafir story github

From David ross <davross99@hotmail.com>

Date Fri 7/31/2026 3:38 PM

To David ross <davross99@hotmail.com>

ZAFIR: OUT OF THE OASIS — Game 1

Full story with 100 gaps | Top 20 irregular verbs | B2 level | Journey structure

Zafir belongs to the Sahar, a small, easy-going community of spirit-creatures who live openly alongside humans, with no fixed duty or role. He leaves his home oasis out of simple curiosity, drawn by news of the Festival of Lights in the city of Qalhara. This chapter is the journey itself — the oasis, the desert crossing (with a sandstorm and a canyon rest along the way), and arrival at Qalhara, ending on a cliffhanger.

Target verbs (20): be, have, do, say, go, get, make, know, think, see, come, take, find, give, tell, feel, become, leave, put, mean

Structure: 5 waves × 20 gaps = 100, all 20 verbs once per wave. Past simple dominates narration; present tense and modal/infinitive constructions appear only inside direct speech or clearly non-past grammatical contexts.

WAVE 1 — The Oasis of Sahar

At the edge of the great desert there ___1(be) a hidden oasis called Zafira's Rest, and a small, easy-going community known as the Sahar ___2(make) their home among the palms there.

Every member of the Sahar ___3(know) the oasis like an old friend, from the coolest shade to the deepest pool, and Zafir ___4(have) a favorite spot beside the water, where his blue fur caught the last light of evening.

Each morning he ___5(go) swimming with his closest friends, and afterward he ___6(feel) perfectly content to do nothing more than nap in the shade until the sun grew too hot to bear.

He ___7(think) his days would always look exactly like this, simple and unhurried, until one afternoon a group of desert traders ___8(come) through the oasis to rest their camels and refill their water skins.

Zafir ___9(see) them first, and he ___10(take) an immediate interest in their strange, dusty packs and the stories they carried with them.

"We ___11(get) here just before sunset," one trader said, wiping the dust from her sleeve, "and tomorrow we travel on to Qalhara, where the whole city is getting ready for the Festival of Lights."

The trader ___12(tell) stories of towers strung with lanterns and a marketplace so large a person could get lost in it for days, and Zafir ___13(find) himself asking question after question, hungry for every last detail.

"You ___14(mean) the whole city lights up at once?" he asked, wide-eyed, and the trader only ___15(give) a small nod, clearly amused by his excitement.

He ___16(do) something he almost never did that night: he lay awake staring at the stars, letting his mind wander far past the edge of the oasis.

He did not ___17(say) anything to his friends the next morning, not at first, but the thought of the festival would not ___18(leave) him alone.

By evening, he had quietly ___19(put) the idea firmly in his head, and something in him had already begun to ___20(become) restless for the road ahead.

WAVE 2 — The Long Goodbye

The next morning, Zafir ___21(go) straight to the oasis elders and told them he wanted to

travel to Qalhara with the traders.

"You ___22(know) the desert can be dangerous for someone who has never left the oasis," the eldest of the Sahar warned, though her eyes ___23(be) kind rather than stern. Zafir ___24(say) he understood the risks, but he ___25(feel) certain that this was something he needed to do for himself.

His friend Yara, another young member of the Sahar, decided she wanted to come too, and together they ___26(make) a simple plan: they would leave with the traders at first light.

Zafir ___27(have) very little to pack, only a small woven bag and a smooth blue stone from his favorite pool, which he wanted to ___28(give) to the eldest as a promise that he would return.

"I ___29(think) you are both very brave, or perhaps very foolish," the eldest said with a small smile, "but I will not stop you."

Zafir ___30(find) it hard to look away from the oasis as they packed their things, and for a moment he almost ___31(leave) the blue stone behind out of nerves.

That evening, the whole community ___32(come) together for a small farewell gathering, and everyone ___33(tell) Zafir and Yara to be careful and to come home safely.

As they said their goodbyes, Zafir ___34(see) tears in Yara's mother's eyes, though she smiled and told them to enjoy every moment of the journey.

Zafir ___35(take) one last long look at the glowing pool before the sun disappeared behind the dunes.

Early the next morning, before the traders ___36(get) their camels ready, Zafir and Yara ___37(put) their small bags onto one of the spare camels and climbed up beside them.

Zafir did not quite know what leaving the oasis would ___38(mean) for him, only that he was ready to ___39(do) it, whatever came next, and as the oasis grew smaller behind them, something in him quietly began to ___40(become) a little more sure of himself with every step.

WAVE 3 — Into the Desert

For three days, Zafir and Yara ___41(be) part of the traders' caravan, learning the slow rhythm of desert travel: walk before dawn, rest through the worst heat, and walk again as the sky cooled toward evening.

Zafir ___42(have) never seen so much empty sand in his life, and at first the endless dunes ___43(make) him a little dizzy.

He ___44(think) the desert would feel lonely, but instead he ___45(find) something oddly peaceful in its silence, broken only by the soft steps of the camels.

One of the traders, an older man named Rafiq, ___46(tell) Zafir stories about the stars each night, showing him how travelers ___47(know) which way was north just by looking up.

On the fourth afternoon, the wind ___48(get) stronger without warning, and within minutes the whole caravan ___49(see) a wall of sand rising on the horizon.

Rafiq shouted a warning as a storm ___50(come) rushing toward them across the dunes, and everyone ___51(go) quickly to shelter the camels and cover their faces with cloth.

Zafir ___52(take) Yara's hand and pulled her close as the sand ___53(become) a stinging, howling blur around them, and for a long, frightening stretch of time, no one could ___54(say) a single word over the roar of the wind.

When the storm finally passed, Zafir ___55(give) a shaky laugh of relief, and Rafiq ___56(put) a steady hand on his shoulder. "You ___57(do) well for someone who has never seen a sandstorm before," he said warmly.

The next day, the caravan turned off the main track to rest at a hidden canyon Rafiq knew well, where cool pools of water collected beneath a small waterfall between high red rock walls. Zafir ___58(feel) a rush of relief the moment he saw the green plants and clear water after so much empty sand, and for the first time since the storm he let himself relax completely.

Yara said the canyon ___59(mean) they could finally wash the sand from their fur and rest their tired feet, and by evening neither of them wanted to ___60(leave) the cool

shade of the rocks.

WAVE 4 — The Long Road

By the sixth day, the caravan ____61(be) close enough to Qalhara that Zafir could see its walls rising pale gold against the sky.

More travelers ____62(come) onto the road with every mile, merchants and pilgrims and musicians all moving toward the same festival, and the road itself ____63(become) busy and loud in a way the desert had never been.

Zafir ____64(have) to admit that the noise and color of it all ____65(make) his heart race with excitement.

"I ____66(think) I have never seen so many people in one place," he said to Yara, who ____67(feel) exactly the same wonder written across her face.

Rafiq ____68(tell) them that the road would join a wide caravan route just outside the city gates, where guards ____69(take) a careful look at everyone entering during festival season.

Zafir ____70(find) the checkpoint fascinating, watching merchants unload silks and spices while camels waited patiently in long lines.

He ____71(get) his first close look at a real city gate, tall enough that ten camels could ____72(go) through it side by side.

For just a moment, in the crowd near the gate, he ____73(see) a tall figure in dark robes moving quickly through the noise, though he ____74(say) nothing of it to Yara, unsure why the sight had unsettled him at all.

He ____75(do) his best to shake off the strange feeling, telling himself it ____76(mean) nothing at all in a city this size.

Rafiq ____77(give) both of them a final piece of advice before they reached the gate: "Stay close to each other, and don't ____78(leave) the main roads until you know the city better."

Zafir ____79(put) the warning carefully in his mind, and he ____80(know) already that Qalhara was going to be nothing like the quiet oasis he had left behind.

WAVE 5 — The Gates of Qalhara (cliffhanger)

At last, Zafir and Yara ____81(be) inside the walls of Qalhara, and the city ____82(take) his breath away completely.

Lanterns of every color glowed above the streets, and the smell of roasting spices and sweet pastries ____83(make) his stomach growl with hunger.

Rafiq ____84(say) goodbye to them near the marketplace, promising to ____85(find) them again before the caravan left the city.

Zafir ____86(feel) a small pang of nervousness as the trader disappeared into the crowd, but Yara ____87(give) him a reassuring smile and pulled him toward the noise and color ahead.

They ____88(go) from stall to stall, tasting strange sweets and admiring silk scarves in colors the oasis had never seen.

Zafir ____89(think) he could spend a lifetime here and still not see everything the city had to offer.

As evening fell, musicians ____90(come) out into the squares, and dancers ____91(get) the whole crowd moving together under the lantern light.

Zafir ____92(know) he would remember this night for the rest of his life, however long that turned out to be.

Then, just as the first fireworks lit up the sky above the palace, Zafir ____93(see) the same tall figure in dark robes again — this time standing perfectly still near the palace steps, watching the crowd instead of joining it.

Something about the stillness ____94(tell) him this was not simply a curious traveler.

He ____95(do) not have time to think about it further, because Yara ____96(have) no patience left for waiting and pulled him toward the palace square, eager not to miss the fireworks.

Zafir ____97(leave) the strange feeling behind for now, telling himself it probably ____98(mean) nothing.

But he ____99(put) the memory carefully aside all the same, a small quiet warning he did

not yet understand — and somewhere above the noise and light of the festival, Qalhara was only just ____100(become) the place where his whole story was about to change.

[END OF GAME 1 — cliffhanger: who is the figure in dark robes, and why does he keep watching Zafir instead of the festival?]

ANSWER KEY

Wave 1: 1.was 2.made 3.knew 4.had 5.went 6.felt 7.thought 8.came 9.saw 10.took 11.got 12.told 13.found 14.mean 15.gave 16.did 17.say 18.leave 19.put 20.become

Wave 2: 21.went 22.know 23.were 24.said 25.felt 26.made 27.had 28.give 29.think 30.found 31.left 32.came 33.told 34.saw 35.took 36.got 37.put 38.mean 39.do 40.become

Wave 3: 41.were 42.had 43.made 44.thought 45.found 46.told 47.knew 48.got 49.saw 50.came 51.went 52.took 53.became 54.say 55.gave 56.put 57.did 58.felt 59.meant 60.leave

Wave 4: 61.was 62.came 63.became 64.had 65.made 66.think 67.felt 68.told 69.took 70.found 71.got 72.go 73.saw 74.said 75.did 76.meant 77.gave 78.leave 79.put 80.knew

Wave 5: 81.were 82.took 83.made 84.said 85.find 86.felt 87.gave 88.went 89.thought 90.came 91.got 92.knew 93.saw 94.told 95.did 96.had 97.left 98.meant 99.put 100.becoming

Flagged for MC-option double-check (non-simple-past forms — present tense in direct speech, modal + base form, infinitive, or continuous participle; correct answer is NOT plain past tense): 14, 17, 18, 20, 22, 28, 29, 38, 39, 54, 57, 60, 66, 72, 78, 85, 100.

(Note: this flagged list now includes 28 and 60, both infinitives after "wanted to," which weren't present in the earlier pre-canyon version. Double check these carefully when writing multiple-choice distractors, alongside the rest of the flagged list.)

IMAGE PROMPTS — reference list

Full image prompts have been developed and iteratively refined separately in conversation (Scenes 1–9 finalized/in progress as of this document). This script file is for wording and gap accuracy; see the separate image-prompt thread for the current, locked-in visual style block and individual scene prompts, including the added canyon scene (Scene 8) that corresponds to the new Wave 3 passage above.

Sent from [Outlook for Android](#)